

THE CROSSROADS

KHEL MELA EDITION

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CHINMAYA
JAYANTI

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DO NOT SEE**
The Editorial

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The Dangers We Don't See

Dear readers,
Hari Om!

I'd like to introduce to you a concept that you have seldom come across. It is the **power of words**, and how they impact our brains in ways that we can hardly even begin to understand.

Now, I shall describe the same image in five different ways.

STATEMENT 1: A delectable dessert, a creamy delight for young and old!

STATEMENT 2: A tasty way to end a meal, with a rich, sweet flavor.

STATEMENT 3: A milk-based dessert with great taste but certain hindrances to health.

STATEMENT 4: An unhealthy option to end a meal, with several preservatives and processed ingredients that cause harm to the human body.

STATEMENT 5: A repulsive piece of processed junk, with nothing good for the body in it.



As you read through the five statements, you will find that they become increasingly opposed to ice cream. The first statement praises ice cream as though it is the noblest of creations known to man. The second also supports ice cream, but with less conviction. The third is objective in its tone, and the fourth and fifth are opposed to the ice cream, with the fifth one being very vehemently so. This is a simple illustration of the subtle impact that words have on the human psyche. All the statements are true - ice cream is indeed palatable, but its adverse effects on health are undeniable.

Now, consider five children who see this ice cream for the first time. They sit down at the restaurant table, and are served this with each of the five statements given to one child. The child that receives the first statement will develop, assumably, a fervent passion for the ice cream that may persist well into his adulthood, whereas the child that receives the fifth statement will likely fling his next bowl of ice cream into the local dumpster, with little regard for the taste.

This example is a simple means of understanding the power of words - the same reality, conveyed differently, produces a different mental reaction in each case. However, like all powers in the world, it is a force that can be used for good and evil. We can simply mull upon this colorful experiment and let it go at that. But the truth is that this entire scenario is merely an allegory for a very serious problem that plagues the Bharatiya youth of today, a problem that could potentially herald the downfall of our civilization. Let's pull back the curtains of the allegory for a moment, so we may glimpse the reality within.

The ice cream is, in fact, our own Bharatiya culture. The restaurant table is the world, and the five children are none other than our own - the next generation of scientists, artists, leaders and educators that will move the nation forward. The statements, instead of speaking of the ice cream, will now speak instead of Bharatiya culture. To illustrate this, I shall conjure another set of five statements, or rather, headlines of media outlets.

HEADLINE 1: Bharat's culture hailed as world's richest, celebrated for immense contributions to the global landscape.

HEADLINE 2: Another heap of praise for Bharat's cultural heritage, called "ancient but beautiful" by world leaders.

HEADLINE 3: "Culture of Bharat is valuable, but has minor tarnishes on history", says minister of a foreign country.

HEADLINE 4: "Not inclusive of others": How India seeks to dominate fellow cultures.

HEADLINE 5: India's oppressive culture is not just impacting its own people, but those across its borders as well.

Please note that all of these headlines are entirely fictional.

Now think of an impressionable little boy in a small village in some corner of the nation, who hardly has more than a brief introduction to Bharat's culture. If he reads the first headline, he is bound to be enamoured by it, while the fifth would bring to him nothing but revulsion and resentment. Therefore, the fifth child will grow up with a mild tilt away from his civilizational identity. As he devours more and more of such vicious, vindictive mirages parading as the truth, he shall turn from a once-rooted young boy into an ideologically twisted shell of himself. These are the adults that one might see roaming the nation in the present day, believing themselves to be heightened intellectuals while they are little more than the sum-products of the various misinformations and crooked media that they have so voraciously consumed.

This all sounds rather far-fetched. Our elders never teach us to hate our own culture. **But other people do.** In the global cultural landscape, there are those that wish nothing more than to see the fall of Bharatiya civilization, and the easiest manner to execute this would be to extricate her people from their distinct national identity. It therefore becomes our duty as citizens of our nation and torchbearers of our civilization to educate ourselves and future generations of these threats to our continuity as a collective. The problem is not that we are ignorant, it is that we stay ignorant. The world is no longer a place where we can close our eyes and continue to mind only our business.

There is a particular reason that I chose to write on this particular topic this time. I am aware that parents and elders will constitute a significant portion of this edition's readership. It is my humble request to you all to pursue a sound grasp of this reality. It is termed '**ideological conversion**' and has come to be one of the foremost blights on the mental nourishment of our youth. We must identify its sources, alert ourselves and others to them, and remain ever-rooted in the culture that we call ours.



BASKETBALL

ARMAAN BAHETI | GRADE 10, CIRS



Basketball. What is it? Two hoops, a ball, and ten players. That's it – isn't it? That's all I thought was there was to the game some time ago. Now, three years later, here I am, standing before you and telling you that I was dead wrong.

This game requires a lot more mental strength than one might imagine. The stamina you need to run back for defense after missing a basket. The tenacity you need to get up stronger after getting tapped by a six-foot-tall beast of an opponent. The strength you need after losing a tournament in just the second round to bounce back and claim the throne as the champions of the district in the next one.

This mentality, as Sundarmoorthi coach says, is crucial to success in both basketball and life. Coach always says that it is not the wins which matter the most. Instead, it is the game which you display out there in the match that matters. The cold determination you need to get up every day at five a.m. and start hooping is one of the aspects of being a great player; and to go back at 9 in the morning to tackle the other - more difficult challenge - of academics is another one. This game has changed me a lot from the inside as well as from the outside.

From being a person who would get agitated about the most miniscule of mistakes to the player who was standing calm when we were up 49-48 in the semi-finals, this game has helped me cultivate my physical and mental wellbeing.

It has also helped me develop my interactions with everyone around me. Now basketball isn't just a

sport for me, it is a place where I go to cool down after the heat of cyclic tests, a safe space to vent out the emotions accumulated throughout the course of my day. It is a place where I go to attain true joy.

This sport has helped me forge special bonds that will last a lifetime. It introduced me to some of my closest and most trusted friends, some of whom are editors in this newsletter! Now, if there is any complication or problem in my life, I feel really comfortable sharing it with them and asking for their help in resolving the issue.

Basketball has also made me a really strong and confident individual who is always ready to help anyone in need. It helped me become a person who is not afraid to express his feelings, but also understands when to do what.

The most important thing which I learnt from this chapter of my life is dedication for, and determination to, something higher than myself. Before playing basketball, I used to play cricket. But I had absolutely no dedication towards that sport. After starting to play basketball, however, I felt inspired to consistently improve in one sport. This chapter of my life was really entertaining and amazing. I not only had a lot of fun, but also learnt many life lessons from it. This is a special part of my life, and one that I will never forget because of the immense hard work put in by our dear Sundaramoorthi coach, and thanks to the insane memories I made with my basketball team.

Conquering the Mind

HRITIK BHAGERIA | GRADE 10, CIRS

In our everyday life, we come across numerous things that fascinate us and direct our attention towards them. This attraction towards the objects that we come across leads one towards desires. However, the primary question still stands: Is it okay to have these desires? That is precisely what is discussed by Pujya Gurudev Swami Chinmayananda in one of his books - 'Conquering the Mind'. This book explores the basic ideas of life and how a person is confined within his world of desires. This is the reason why one needs to have control over one's mind or in other words, "conquer" it.

The first step towards conquering the mind is detachment from worldly desires. Well, worldly desires are simply the urge to obtain objects, and one only wants those objects that provide happiness. The urge to possess an object gets more and more powerful and takes absolute control over one's mind. When a single desire gains control over one's mind, the fascinations toward any other objects automatically fall away.

In 'Conquering the Mind', Gurudev deals with concepts that make us realize the importance of having control over your mind. It includes the small habits that we come across everyday and pay very less attention to such as concentration. These large concepts have been discussed in small and easy words within just 12 pages! In such a small book, you understand that such small things make a big difference in your overall growth. That is what makes this even more interesting. But one question still remains: What after that? In fact, this skill of controlling the mind goes beyond overcoming our desires.

When your mind is under your control, you start to entertain the kind of thoughts that influence you to become the best version of yourself. This changes your view about everything you come across. The changes are evident. Let's understand this with an example - a man who criticizes everything. Versus a man who starts to love and respect everything. This can be done in many ways, but the most prominent one is something that we are in close contact with: meditation.

Meditation. The first thing that we think about is calmness and tranquility. All that we just talked about must be practiced through your daily sadhana. Think about it - when you are detached from the materialistic world and constantly aspire to take control of your mind, your mind whilst meditating will not entertain any kind of thought. That is when you take control over your mind and understand the true potential that your mind can unlock.

Being CIRS students, we come across these concepts very frequently in morning spiritual classes and interactions with our teachers. Yet, we tend to underestimate the power of these small changes. When you apply these concepts in your life, they make an immense difference. Our Pujya Gurudev had this very vision - to empower the youth for a better future. He achieved this vision with his talks and writings. This is just one masterpiece among Gurudev's many works. These books are widely available and also easy to understand. So let us live the vision that Gurudev had for us and follow his footsteps towards a happy and dynamic world!

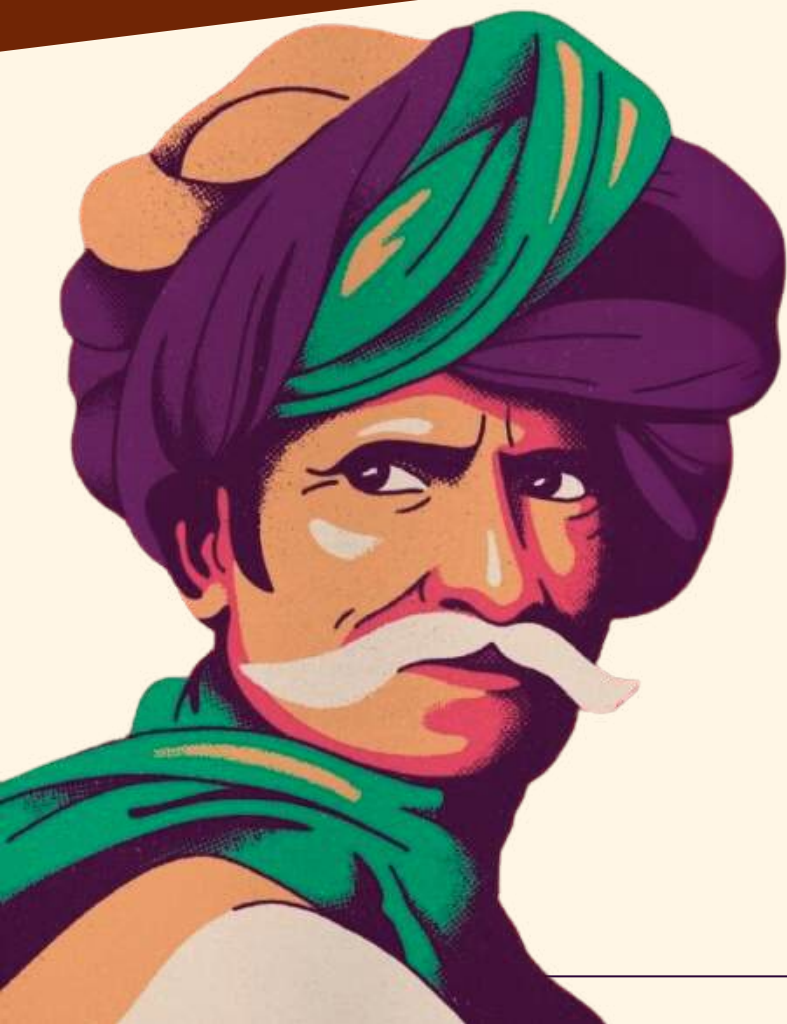
NAVIGATING THE CROSSROADS

Tradition & Modernity

- Chinmaya Yuva Kendra CIRS

In recent times, Bharat has witnessed a growing tension between traditional attire and modern fashion. This clash has come to the fore, with incidents like a woman being turned away from a Gurugram pub for wearing a sari and a man being barred from a Bengaluru mall for donning a dhoti. These incidents underscore a deeper cultural divide in contemporary Bharat, where traditional garments are often perceived as outdated, beneath one's stature, and, in Gen Z terms, 'very cheugy'.

In urban centers like Gurugram and Bengaluru, where global fashion trends dominate, traditional attire like the sari and dhoti are seen as out of sync with contemporary lifestyles. This disconnect is fueled by a complex interplay of factors, including the influence of Western culture and the rapid pace of urbanization.



For some, traditional attire is seen as a symbol of cultural heritage and identity. However, many others see it as impractical or even restrictive. This clash between tradition and modernity reflects a broader societal tension between the desire for being "global" and the need to preserve cultural heritage.

In today's fast-paced world, traditional attire can often feel out of place. The sari and dhoti, deeply rooted in Bharatiya culture and history, are sometimes relegated to special occasions or traditional settings. This shift in perception is influenced by a variety of factors, including the increasing influence of Western fashion and the association of modernity with global trends.

While globalization has brought about opportunities for cultural exchange, it has also led to a certain degree of cultural homogenization.

In Bharat, this has manifested in a tension between embracing global trends and preserving local traditions. While many young Bharatiyas are keen to embrace global fashion, there is also a growing awareness of the importance of cultural identity rooted in donning one's traditional attire.

To bridge the gap between tradition and modernity, it is essential to reclaim our cultural identity and celebrate our rich heritage. This involves recognizing the beauty and significance of traditional attire and incorporating it into contemporary fashion. By doing so, we can challenge outdated stereotypes and foster a more inclusive and culturally sensitive society.

Fashion designers and influencers can play a crucial role in this task by re-imagining Western clothing with an Indian flavor to it. Re-defining modernity in Indian terms is the need of the hour. This can help us create a class of citizens whose very idea of modernity will include a strong sense of cultural identity.

Addressing this cultural divide requires a multi-faceted approach. Educational initiatives can help raise awareness about the cultural significance of traditional attire, while fashion trends can promote traditional garments for contemporary audiences. Sabyasachi's simplicity or Anita Dongre's elegance and even Masaba Gupta's flamboyance play an important role in this endeavor.

Ultimately, the choice of what to wear is a personal one. However, it is important to create a society where individuals feel empowered to express their cultural identity through their clothing choices. It is important to create individuals who have respect for and reverence to their unique national culture and do not seek to fit in with global paradigms to accentuate their self-worth. By embracing our traditions and celebrating our diverse origins, we can build a more inclusive and culturally vibrant future.



CHYK
All India Chinmaya Yuvakendra

ARE YOU READY TO MAKE A DIFFERENCE?
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YOU ARE NOT THE BODY; YOU ARE
THE ESSENCE, THE SELF, THE
DIVINE ENTITY WITHIN.
- SWAMI CHINMAYANANDA

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My friendship with CU began during a spiritual class last year, when I received a red-colored magazine sporting a cover page with faces fiercer than any I had ever seen. That immediately caught my eye although I had never opened an **Udghosh** magazine in my life, and wasn't expecting too much from it. That was when our Spiritual teacher, Narayanji, explained to us what that particular issue was dedicated to: the mighty Marathas and their leader Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj. After reading the magazine, I felt a new urge. An overwhelming desire to change. To transform. I found the stories and articles in CU to be so powerful and deep, that it made we want to read more. I felt very energetic that day, and since then I have read every single CU issue that has been released by the Chinmaya Mission with utmost curiosity and reverence. From Gurudev's enlightening articles to anecdotes from the epics. From fun travelogues to descriptive accounts of Bharat's culture, CU has it all! The spiritual, intellectual and cultural changes I have undergone because of this magazine have been truly phenomenal.

- *Konasani Rampraneel Reddy*
IB I Year, CHYK Mauryas Batch 1

Evolution OF THEATER



ADHVIKA K. | GRADE 9, CIRS

Imagine societies devoid of culture, entire civilizations that have evolved without having created their own painting styles, dance forms or literary works. Quite unimaginable, right? This is because it is culture alone that can turn a mere collection of people into a civilization. As seen across a plethora of civilizations, art forms remain one of the most notable aspects of culture. The art forms of Bharat are what build up the extravagant and theatrical side of India. From dances like Bharatanatyam that leave viewers awestruck, to depictions of a variety of expressions in Kalaripayattu, the exploration of Bharatiya theater transports us into a whole new world.

The origins of theater are said to be in the city of Athens in ancient Greece. Greeks respected theater as a form of worship to their gods. Their social gatherings were commonly artists, writers or poets presenting their work to the masses. Owing to sea trade routes and the colonization of foreign lands, the concept of theater spread like fire across the globe to places inhabited by people who followed completely different belief systems and had different perspectives on life. This difference in perception is exactly what led to the differences in theatrical cultures across the globe.

Every era has minds that brought along a fresh set of ideas that made revolutionary changes. These changes transformed the societal standards of theater. Thus, each period ---

has its own significance in relation to theater style and production. One of the biggest transformations in theater took place in the 19th century during the French Revolution. Besides being the spearhead of all future revolutions, this historical event also provided a new face to theater. When the term 'theater of the Olden Times' hits our eardrums, all we think of is Shakespeare. However, the French Revolution was the first to utilize theater as a medium to reach out to people across villages and towns, when the middle-class folk put up plays and other performances to showcase their ideas and possible solutions to the conflict. These plays hugely impacted the minds of the people, helping shape their thoughts, opinions and actions. Although these changes seemed to be insignificant; it was these small actions that ultimately became a powerful force, changing the future of the people and the country.

On the other side of the planet, South Asians enjoyed theatrical performances purely as a form of entertainment. Most plays' scripts were written by great playwrights, and such plays continue to be acted, narrated and sung to the people even today. The continuation of these plays help the youth of the present hold on to their rich past, which still continues to teach them lessons in various ways. Nowadays, theater is associated with buttery popcorn and movie stars.

The impact of classical theater around the globe is slowly fading, being replaced instead by plasma screens. Theater formerly served as a means of protest, a method of spreading awareness about global issues. Today, it is limited to horror flicks and romantic tragedies. In fact, the masquerades in our very own CIRS breathe the spirit of theater into the school and its students. They bring out the emotional aspect of acting, and create more impact. They are a reminder of the sheer power that theater wields, bringing people together in celebration of the grandeur and majesty of drama.



RISHI CHOTHAN | IB I YEAR, CIRS

VIB HO OTI

What makes you brave? What makes you curious? What makes you want to get out there and explore? This year, the effervescent eleventh grade went on what they claim to be the best Educational Tour they've ever been on. Now, I'm no CIRS veteran, but let me tell you: I'm willing to believe them because that tour was probably the second most fun thing I've ever done in my life. Khel Mela preparations with Vyasa House take first place.

The tour started off with us leaving for the airport at the brink of dawn. But since I myself tend to forget that I'm an eleventh grader sometimes (I'm the only eleventh grader who lives upstairs), I can't really blame anyone for not waking me up! And so, despite the rouser being set for 4:30, I was awakened at 5:00 a.m. and had about twenty minutes to get ready. Great start to the trip, if you ask me. We flew to Powai, Mumbai and proceeded to the heart of the Chinmaya mission, the very crux of it: The Central Chinmaya Mission Trust's ashram. Here, we learnt about the trials and tribulations Gurudev endured as a freedom fighter, his contribution to the strength of the youth of today and about his life in general. Afterwards, Swami Avyayananda blessed us with his presence and conducted a session. He even sang a song for us. After a scrumptious lunch with donuts and some special prasad from Swami Swaroopanandaji, we took our leave. Where we would go next, we knew. But what we did not know was how much fun it would turn out to be.



After a six-hour-long, masti-filled bus ride, we arrived at our destination. We arrived at Z-Bac, an adventure institute founded and crafted by Sri Prasad Deole. It was pretty late when we reached, so we had dinner and headed to bed, sorry, tent. We expected the tents, but what we did not expect were the millions of bugs and creepy-crawlies which were experiencing the vagaries of nature along with us - welcome to forest life. The next few days were probably the best few of our lives. We rappelled, rock-climbed and even built our own rafts and raced on them. We ziplined, we trekked, we learnt how to survive. Oh and how could I forget the outdoor make-shift showers? Over the course of 4 days and 3 nights, we found ourselves becoming good friends with our roommates: the bugs. Some of us (most of us) became comfortable with doing things we weren't comfortable with before. The sessions Prasadji held were incredible. One incident that really stuck with me was when he asked us to think of different emotions. We thought and thought and eventually came up with 17 different emotions. Five of them were good emotions and the remaining were negative. When he connected the five pandavas with this activity, everyone in the room lost their minds. It's a small thing but there were so many more instances like this that were absolutely mind-blowing. We celebrated our stay in Z-Bac with a bonfire night filled with dances and songs.

For our next adventure, we rendezvoused with Sri Pundlik Sitaram in Raigad, Maharashtra. The view from Raigad was breathtaking but more so was the trek we were about to go on. We quickly had some breakfast and proceeded to climb the Raigad Fort - the capital of the visionary, the warrior-king Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj. One thousand seven hundred steps, four thousand feet above sea level and two hours of pure, unparalleled fun and challenge. Pundlik Ji's son headed the whole trek and wow, was he an amazing kid! Through donkeys and monkeys we journeyed, and across rocks and waterfalls we trekked. At the top, we were greeted by one of the greatest, most beautiful views ever. The fort itself, built by Hiroji Indulkar, was a work of art with so many interesting passageways and hidden paths. Meandering across the horizon were mountains, fluid clouds and tiny streams of water. We explored the fort and took in the scenery until the time had come for us to leave. We thought the fun ended there but no, we had just one more thing: a cable car all the way back down.

After another voyage and yet another bus ride, we made our way to Chinmaya Vibhooti, another integral part of the Chinmaya Mission. "Vibhooti" means glory, and after a look around the sixty-five acres of serene, pictorial environment, I don't think anyone could argue with that. We got to experience the Chinmaya Jeevan Darshan, a monument showcasing the teachings, vision, life and work of Swami Chinmayananda through an exquisite amalgamation of paintings, stories and sculptures. Some things, however, really caught my attention. For instance, the life-like wax sculpture of Swamiji, the room dedicated to his personal belongings, the murals from the movie 'On A Quest' and so much more.

It's a whole new experience to see what you see on screen in real life. Furthermore, we enjoyed the delicious, sattvic food and stayed in the spacious rooms there for a day. Then came perhaps the most interesting part of the whole tour: the Swanubhooti Vatika. I can't even begin to express in words the peace and tranquility exuding from this beautiful place.

It was so captivating, not even two 3 hour long sessions were enough to cover all of it. We made use of the money provided to us at the stores there and left shortly after for the Sant Darshan museum.

Alas, we were nearing the end of our tour but we had to recuperate somewhere. We were invited to the Chinmaya Mauli Ashram where we had some dinner and freshened up. The legendary Arya Bus Tours rolled in and we hit the airport in no time. Now that I write about it, it all seems so small, but it truly was a tour I'd never forget. A tour worthy of the title "Vibhooti".

GOBLIN MODE: THE DARK ABYSS

ATHARV KRISHNA | GRADE 10, CIRS



The world is filled with people that try their best to fit in, work hard and conform to society's definition of "perfect". In such times, exceptions tend to be very, very rare. These outliers are either those who prove society's parameters of perfection to be drastically incorrect, or those that prefer to live in a world of their own creation. In fact, such a state of blissfully independent existence even has a name now: Goblin Mode!

The Cambridge Dictionary defines this term as "the behavior of someone who wants to feel comfortable and do and eat whatever they want, not caring about trying to be clean, healthy, or attractive, or about pleasing or impressing other people."

While this state of being might serve as an attractive short-term solution, preventing one from succumbing to external stress and other pressures, it is definitely not the best recipe for the long-term well-being or success of an individual. When someone enters Goblin Mode, they blatantly defy societal practices and customs that have taken shape over centuries of humanity's evolution. Also, habits and practices that are required to live a healthy and serene life are also sidelined in this frankly debaucherous lifestyle. Simply put, what differentiates a normal human from someone living in Goblin Mode is not their habits per se, but the extent to which they take these habits.

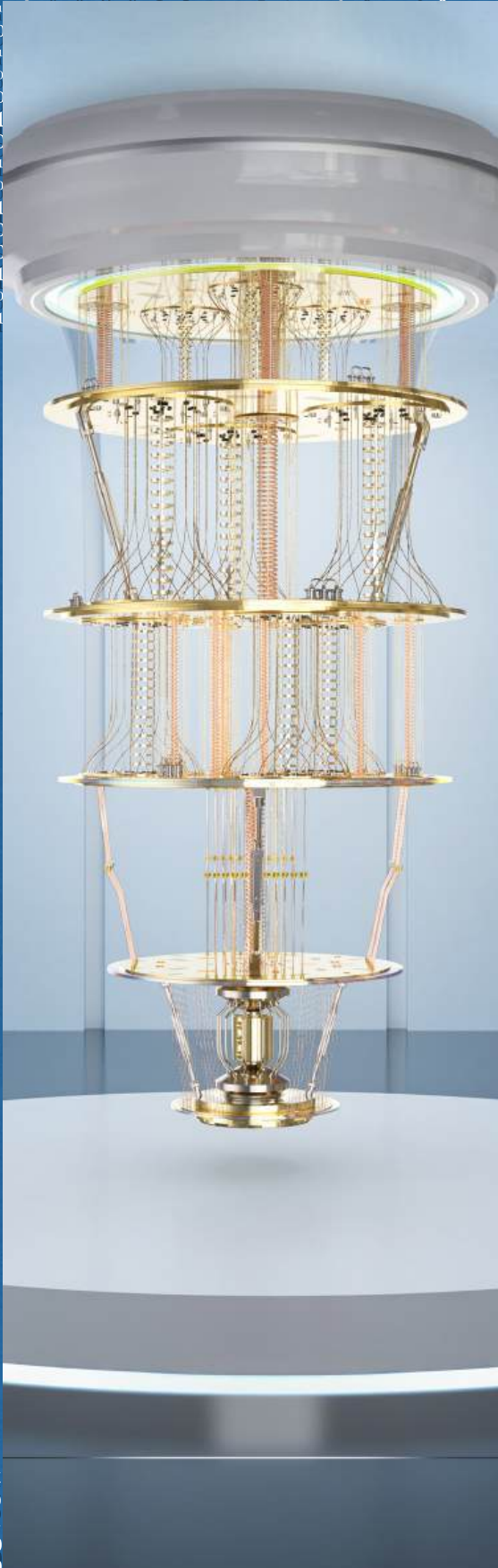
For example, consider the simple practice of taking a bath everyday. Someone in Goblin Mode would not bathe for weeks at a time, just because he feels like it! Thus, Goblin Mode can be as harmful to a person's health as it is to his mindset. Goblin Mode is an unhealthy state of self-indulgence that can cause a human to live completely disconnected from the world outside. However, a person can easily resist falling into this spiral of self-destruction through simple discipline and intelligent self-restraint.



The most simple method is motivation - not just the external kind, but the internal sort as well. Motivation is that uplifting feeling, which keeps you going no matter the circumstances. It can be found while striving for a greater ideal, or by setting realistic goals to keep you working steadily. Also, many slow and gradual changes must be made on a personal level to exit Goblin Mode. These can include changes in routine or the establishment of balance between comforts and necessities. Getting physically active through regular exercise also goes a long way in promoting positive mental health, arresting one's fall into Goblin Mode. In conclusion, Goblin Mode is a state of being that puts us and the world around in a state of continuous retardation. Hence, it is the need of the hour that such unchecked self-indulgence be kept under control at all times for our growth and development as individuals.

QUANTUM COMPUTING

Aryan I. G. | Grade 10, CIRS



Believe it or not, the first computer dates back to more than 2000 years ago. An analog computer of incredible complexity, it was designed to map the motion of the moon, planets and stars. Over the years, these evolved from notches carved into bones to the first metallic machine crafted in 1822 by Charles Babbage. With hundreds of gears and levers to pull, you could calculate latitudes, longitudes and surprisingly, even interest rates! But during World War II, when the Germans were producing highly encrypted military messages using their code machine Enigma, this computer failed to crack the code. The job to decrypt them was given to the young mathematicians of the era; one such innovator was the legendary Alan Turing. He invented the Bombe, which marked the first shift from analog to digital processing, with transistors operating on ones and zeroes. In fact, Turing's contribution to the field of computers is so significant that every computer and supercomputer today works on the abstract of Turing.

In 1900, Max Planck gave life to quantum physics. At the time, the visionary physicist Richard Feynman, one of the founders of quantum electrodynamics, asked himself a simple question: "How small can a transistor get?" He realized that the ultimate transistor is the atom. It can conduct or insulate the flow of electricity to such an extent that we can convert signals of not only 1s and 0s, but also everything in between. So the ultimate computer should compute not on transistors, but on atoms. Transistors are based on zeroes and ones, but reality is not. Reality is based on particles and electrons, and all particles in turn act like waves. So we must have newly defined mathematics that explains the waves that make up a molecule. And that is exactly where quantum computers step in and take this technological revolution a huge step further.

Quantum computers use quantum bits, or qubits, to process information. These can exist in multiple states at once, even if they are far away. Using qubits allows us to perform multiple calculations, functions and processes at the same time. Thus, quantum computers give life to inventions never dreamt of. Imagine your watch monitoring your heart rate, taking a call and reminding you to pick up your kids - all at the same time! Today there are huge steps being taken for the development of quantum computing. As the founder of the Artificial Intelligence Lab at Google, Hartmut Neven, rightly said, "A quantum computer will be a gift to future generations, giving them a new tool to solve problems that today are unsolvable."



Picture this: You are gazing out of a window at one of the most beautiful landscapes you will ever see in your life. Majestic mountains stand tall and proud, clouds float so low you can almost touch them, and a lush green garden stretches right underneath your feet. Visualizing paradise? Well, not quite. In fact, this is exactly what we, the 8th graders, experienced on our educational tour this year.

It all started on the 22nd of October at about 3AM in the morning. When we, the 8th graders, woke up with bleary eyes that morning, one thing was clear to all 105 of us - this week-long trip was one that could potentially change our lives. A couple of hours later, any passerby at Coimbatore airport would have seen a sea of grey t-shirts queuing up at the boarding gate, waiting to board the plane to Delhi.

In Delhi, we visited places of deep significance to our country. We went to the Rashtrapati Bhavan Museum, and then visited the India Gate - a breathtaking scene as the sky was painted in vibrant

hues of pink and orange by the setting sun. We also witnessed a solemn ceremony conducted by the Indian Navy in honor of our brave martyrs.

The next destination was the highlight of our trip - Sidhbari. We undertook an overnight train journey to Pathankot before continuing on our way by bus. That bus ride was long and rocky, yet completely worth the experience ahead of us. Above all, we realized that there is something about Sidhbari that one cannot describe with mere words. The scenery I mentioned earlier was seen in this alluring place. Staying here helped all of us calm our minds and contemplate upon our daily lives.

There was a 25-foot-tall Hanuman statue there that we all just fell in love with. Every morning used to start with Gurudev's aarti, followed by Ram aarti and Shiva aarti as well. After this, we went to the Hanuman statue and chanted Hanuman Chalisa. I still remember that on the second day we chanted Hanuman Chalisa 18 times in half an hour! We also had meditation in the mornings and in the evenings, which

really helped us improve our mental state. My favorite God being Hanumanji, I always used to look forward to those sessions in the area surrounding the statue.

Aside from the spiritual side of our tour, we also had a whole lot of fun. The highlight of this was the street shopping in McLeod Ganj. We were all sad to leave Sidhbari, but excited about the next leg of our trip which would take us to the land of the five rivers - Punjab! We reached Amritsar after an 8-hour bus ride, and it was almost 10 o'clock when we finally arrived there.

The following day, we started early and went to the ever majestic, ever beautiful Golden Temple. We stood in line for almost one and a half hours and only then did we get a chance to enter the temple. The sheer number of devotees present at this majestic place of worship was astonishing. There were a series of auditoriums underneath the Golden Temple that portrayed the history of the temple and the Sikh religion. We also got the amazing opportunity to drink authentic Punjabi lassi straight from street

shops. After this, we visited Jallianwala Bagh. The atmosphere bore the saddening tinge of a dark history, where many innocent souls had been ruthlessly massacred by the cruel General Dyer and his army. The horrors of this incident remain etched into the walls of the park, in the form of bullet holes, to this day.

The display at the Attari-Wagah Border by the soldiers of the Indian and Pakistani armies was simply unforgettable. The performers from the Indian side kept a crowd of almost 80,000 people entertained throughout the procession. The best part was definitely the march past. For us NCC cadets, the standard of the march past was really something to learn from. The entire display invoked a strong sense of patriotism within all of us. I vividly remember that there was not a sound in the bus on the way back to the hotel that night, as everyone had lost their voices shouting “Bharat Mata Ki Jai!”, “Vande Mataram!” and “Hindustan Zindabad!” at the border.

We reached school after a week of varied, enriching experiences, filled to the brim with new ideas and learnings. This trip was a perfect blend of patriotism, spirituality, education, and, best of all, fun! One thing I can confidently say is that we all returned as transformed individuals, at least in some aspects of our personality. So whenever you find yourself at your wits’ end and want to get out of your city for a while, consider visiting these places for the experience of a lifetime.



BREAKING BARRIERS

KRISHA DOSHI | GRADE 11 MGMT, CIRS

How many of us believe that the role of a priest can only be performed by men? This notion has long been considered a rigid taboo. However, the Durga Puja in 2021 was conducted by four female priestesses in Kolkata! Brazenly shattering such outdated stereotypes, and challenging traditional gender roles in religious practices. This event is not a one-off example of women empowerment. It is part of an amazing trend that is seeing an increasing number of women taking up central roles in religious ceremonies.

The women in this event successfully managed to preserve their traditional methods of celebration, while simultaneously introducing their own unique flair to the ceremonies. Their work not only showcased the rich traditions of Durga Puja, but also broke new ground as to how these festivals are celebrated. How many of us actually know about these trendsetting women? Not many, right? Then allow me to introduce you to these bold, strong and fearless ladies from Kolkata. Today, Nandini Bhowmick, Ruma Roy, Semanti Banerjee, and Paulami Chakraborty stand as proud role models for all of us.

Breaking societal norms was never easy and never will be. But these women have proved that through determination and self effort, it can be aspired for. Not only have they opened new doors for themselves, but they have also paved the way for future generations who want to make a difference. It is now our responsibility to embrace such opportunities, support such changes, and take forward the progress that these remarkable women have set into motion.

girl
up
महत्त्व

4 WAYS TO ENERGIZE YOUR PRESENT SELF THIS VACATION

- The Editorial Team

MAKE TIME FOR EMPTINESS

First, observe yourself

Be with yourself as you are, but without haste, without impatience

In our busy lives, finding time to think about nothing seems impossible. We're constantly pressured by work and daily responsibilities. However, dedicating just ten minutes to emptiness and clearing your mind from distractions can be beneficial. *Just 10 minutes of nothing.*



DISCARD WHAT YOU DON'T NEED

It will refresh your mind

Part with old things before acquiring new ones

When faced with difficulties, we often feel a lack. To improve our situation, we should let go of something before seeking new acquisitions. This idea aligns with simple living and the Bharatiya concept of *Vairagya*, which promotes detachment from both mental and physical attachments for *spiritual refreshment*.



GET IN TOUCH WITH NATURE

Find the happiness that is right at hand

Create a miniature garden in your mind

Pause that Instagram reel and take a moment to rejuvenate by connecting with Mother Nature. Pick up a stone and hold it, smell the flowers blooming by the side of the road, notice the butterflies outside your window. Little things go a long way in brightening up your day.



TRY GOING BAREFOOT

Keep the sickness away

Disorder in your mind shows in your feet

Monks go barefoot 365 days a year. Ever seen one with a cold? Walking barefoot helps your body; it stimulates pressure points on your feet and it's like a massage while you are walking. Walking barefoot connects you with the earth and is believed to act as a grounding action to your energies. People like wearing socks during winter. Warm feet are no match for the pleasure of bare feet.



LET GO TO GROW

KRRISH ANIL HARAN | IB I YEAR, CIRS



All of us carry with us the heavy weight of our past - memories, mistakes, and attachments that dictate our present and define our future. But what if I tell you that true growth lies in releasing this burden? In 'The Art of Thinking Clearly', Rolf Dobelli unpacks the mental traps that tether us to the past, offering profound insights into how letting go is not about forgetting, but rather about freeing ourselves. In a world where clarity and adaptability are key, understanding the power of release becomes essential - not just for survival, but specifically for growth and transformation.

Our past has great power over us, shaping our emotions, choices, and view of life. In 'The Art of Thinking Clearly', Rolf Dobelli delves into cognitive snares that influence our choices, and how letting go does not mean erasing the past but instead understanding how it influences our present. This is imperative in today's world because in releasing the weight of mistakes, attachments, or choices, one can open oneself to clarity and growth.



One of the key concepts discussed by Dobelli in this book is the 'Sunk Cost Fallacy': the tendency to continue something solely because we have invested considerable amounts of time, money or effort into it. Whether it is a relationship that is draining us, or a project we no longer care about, we often let past commitments determine our future direction. Letting go requires us to focus on what is best for our future, rather than being held back by what we've already spent. The freedom to walk away from what no longer serves us is a critical step toward growth.

Dobelli also explores 'Hindsight Bias', which causes us to believe we "knew it all along!" But, of course, only after the event has occurred. This is what results in regret and self-blame, as we convince ourselves that we could have made better decisions if only we had seen things more clearly. However, the fact remains that we take decisions according to the information we have at a particular time. Therefore, to release ourselves from living a life of regret, we must forgive ourselves while learning important lessons constantly.

Another trap is the 'Endowment Effect', wherein we tend to over-value things simply because they belong to us. We might hang on to old possessions, memories, or even achievements that are no longer serving our growth just because we earned them in days gone by. Such emotional baggage only holds us back. Letting go in this situation includes giving up what no longer helps us achieve our current goals. This way, there's space to welcome new experiences and opportunities.

Life's highs and lows naturally tend to balance out over time, a phenomenon Dobelli refers to as "Regression to the Mean". Despite this, we often let past successes or failures define how we approach the present. While past triumphs might set unrealistic expectations, past failures can leave us feeling defeated. We must accept life's inherent balance and focus on steady progress rather than being attracted or consumed by extremes.

Moreover, our tendency to overthink anchors us further to the past as we relive mistakes and regrets over and over again in our minds. This fixation robs us of the ability to live fully in the present moment - the only time we really have control over. Here, letting go involves recognizing when our memories no longer serve us, and redirecting our attention to the possibilities and beauty of the now.

Dobelli's last words of advice are regarding 'Confirmation Bias', something he sees people use to remain stubbornly entrenched in their beliefs. Thus, we remain unable to transform into who and what we can really become. Burning up our previously formed biases with the fire of true knowledge is hence crucial to progress in life.

Finally, letting go of the past is not about erasing it, but freeing ourselves from its malevolent grip. When we let go of emotional attachments and mental traps, we create space for new opportunities and a clearer path forward. As the saying goes, "Painful endings are often just new beginnings in disguise." By unchaining our minds, we empower ourselves to embrace the infinite possibilities of the present and future.



DRIVING INDIA

- What Fuels the Indian Consumer

SAMARTH PODDAR | IB I YEAR, CIRS

Tucson. In India, one of Hyundai's top-selling vehicles ran out of gas. Despite having cutting-edge features, this car's monthly sales figures barely managed to exceed 100 units. However, despite having fewer features, Toyota's Fortuner, which costs 60 lakh rupees, is the best-selling vehicle in its class! Further investigation indicates that neither the product nor the manufacturer is to blame for this.

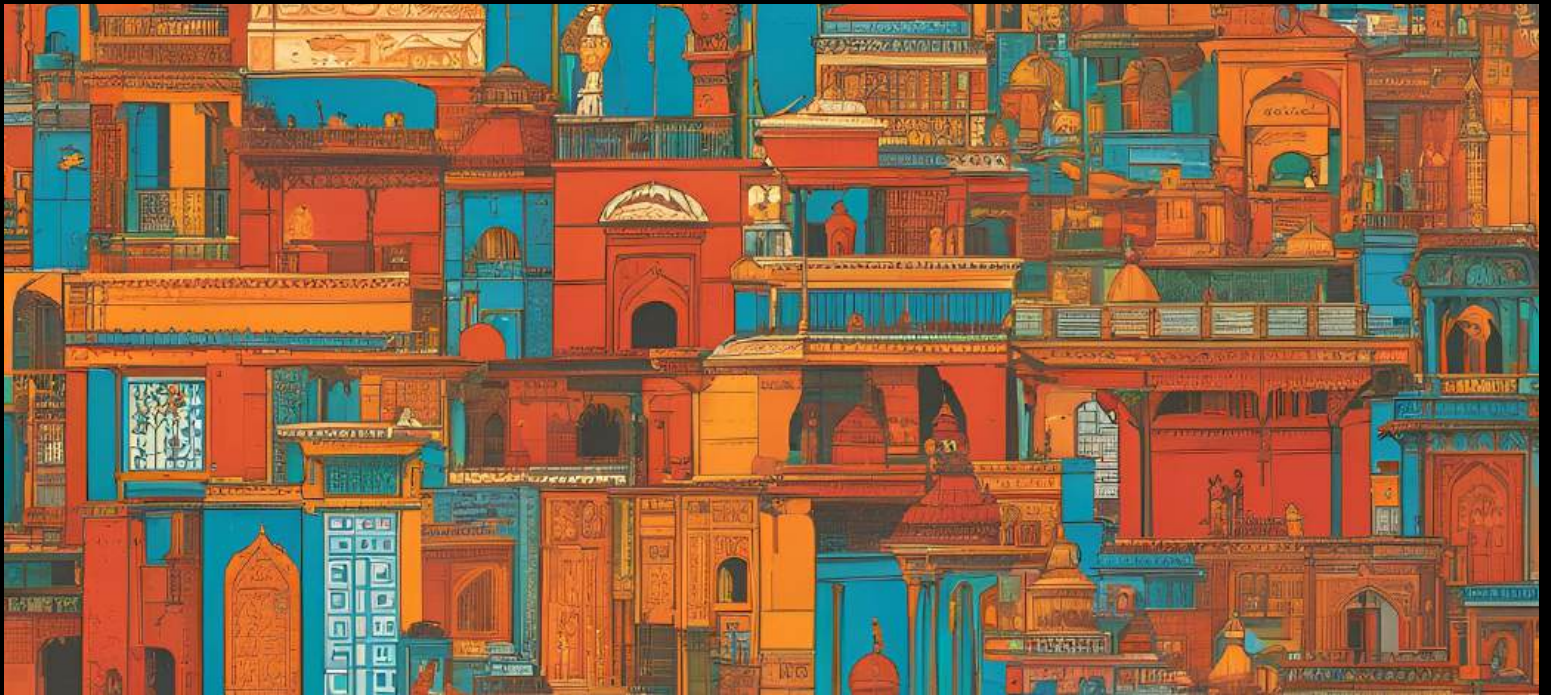
Welcome to the most complex market in the world, ladies and gentlemen. For seasoned entrepreneurs, it is nothing new for established products to fail while rookies succeed. It is high time we navigate through these complexities and discover the ways to capture this market.

Suppose I am the owner of Stratos. A product is considered to have SAVED something for the Indian consumer whenever it is successful. Indian customers are especially renowned for their ability to save money. The company must be in harmony with the environment in which it works. In this instance, a community of frugal, budget-conscious and penny-conscious consumers. Every time someone purchases a Stratos, I would make sure that he feels as though he has made the right choice.



Regarding the automobile industry, Indian consumers want technological features and fuel efficiency. Indians want the feel of a Mercedes in a Maruti. They boast about the money they saved on the purchase when they are given such a pleasure. The amount of satisfaction they are being gifted with is tremendous.

In India, "localization" goes beyond just simply assembling cars together. It involves altering marketing strategies, materials, and designs. Local needs must be met by the vehicles, such as tier-2 and tier-3 cities'



family-oriented designs and urban dwellers' smaller, more economical versions. After introducing the 'Vocal For Local' campaign, Tata Motors' sales continued to rise, and they began to challenge Hyundai for the title of second-largest car producer in India. It's possible that the impact of patriotism in India will encourage all local producers. In India, individuals use the phrases "Chaacha" and "Bhaiya" to address shopkeepers, drivers, coworkers, and even employees.

NETWORKING in India is more than business lunches in formal setups. It is about being there

for people and going out of your way to help them overcome their personal challenges. Trust me, these people, when treated like family, will turn up to help you in your scariest of times. They could be the reason for you reaching the destination you desired, or even getting supplies at a discount. Winning in corporate India requires deep connections with people. Stratos should be able to reach out to employees with a friendly approach. The employees would then work with a sense of belonging and would call the company their own. Their efficiency increases drastically thanks to this improved mentality of inclusiveness.

SPIRITUALITY in India is more than just religion-influenced rituals. It is a ray of hope for many that enables them to overcome their daily challenges. Every business should understand the role of spirituality in India and have respect for it. It is also essential to ensure that products and business ethics match Indian culture. Stratos has to be aligned with India's deep-rooted spirituality and respect for tradition. The brand can integrate spiritual and cultural elements into its identity and operations, reflecting the values of mindfulness, respect, and sustainability. Spirituality has to be infused while still driving innovation and modernity.

In the uniquely Indian concept of JUGAAD (clever adaptability), there lies a philosophy of finding creative, resourceful solutions to challenges, often with limited inputs. Sunil Munjal said when the Hero-Honda partnership was coming to an end that one of the key differences is that the Japanese are very process-oriented. Indians, on the other hand, are great at sidestepping them. They always find a Jugaad. I think Jugaad itself is partially genetic, partially historical, and partially coming from the sheer compulsion of living with shortages of all kinds. While Jugaad is being hailed as the stepping stone in the success of India, it is also inferred to be a blockage in real innovation. Whatever the perceptions of people are, it is surely required to get your work DONE. In Stratos, embracing jugaad can unlock immense potential in a market like India, where frugality, flexibility, and innovation are crucial to success. For instance, instead of spending on expensive advertising, companies can leverage local influencers, social media platforms, and community events.



Lastly, as entrepreneurs, we need to GET IT DONE. Literally speaking, in India the carrot-and-stick approach does not work. In the carrot-stick approach, it so happens that you get a reward for good work and a punishment for poor behavior. The work ethic in India must be improved. It has to be closely monitored – if you don't inspect it, don't expect it.

The key to thriving in India's diverse and dynamic market lies largely in understanding local preferences, adapting products, building strong partnerships, and embracing technology and sustainability. But to WIN IN INDIA, you require a package that must include various skill sets. The market here is truly unpredictable; you never know when people will start hating even money. You always have to be vigilant; whenever you come up with something, look at it from the rational perspective of a consumer. Those lenses of varying perspectives will help you judge the idea in the best possible way. Always remember, winning in India is a real task, and winning ethically makes it all the more tougher. The ethical way faces more perils but definitely gets 100 times the respect.



SOURCE:
A Manual of Self Unfoldment
BY SWAMI CHINMAYANANDA



WHAT IS JAPA?



Learn from
Grade II

Japa is the training for the mind in fixing itself to a single line of thinking.

We cannot pronounce a word without a thought form generated by it immediately in us; nor can we have a thought form without its corresponding name. Try! Can you repeat the word 'pen' without its form? Can you? In this close connection between the name and the form lies the underlying principle in the technique of japa.



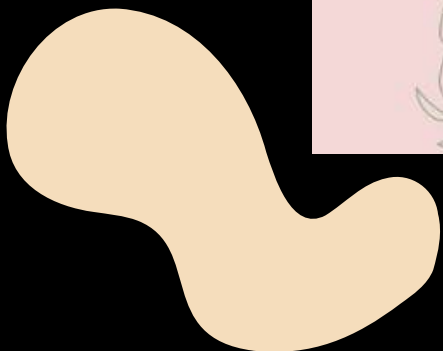
Another important aspect of the technique of japa is that the **principle of attachment** to any object is by repetition of thoughts.

With a continuous repetition of the name of the Lord, one gets attached to Him with a consequent **detachment from the world** and its entanglements.





Japa is a very effective **mental discipline** for spiritual progress.



Captures



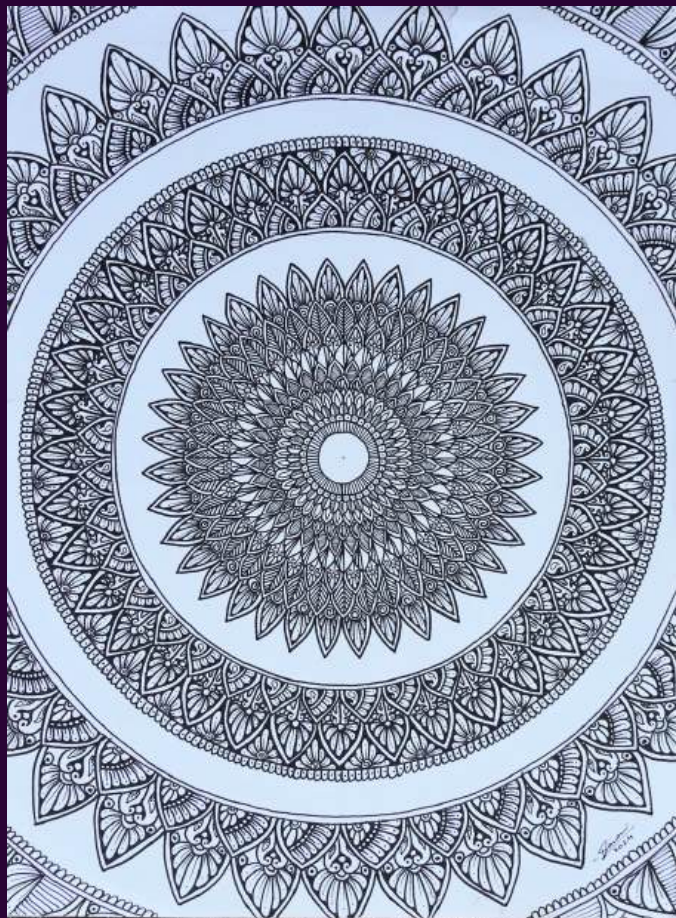
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CREATIVE CORNER



Dhriti S. ~ IB I 



Prahalad S. ~ X 



Pirai S. ~ VII 



Shwet G. ~ IX 



Shresth K. ~ X 

Some act till they meet obstacles, others act in spite of obstacles; but some act not fearing the possibility of obstacles that might arise enroute.

November - December 2024 | Living the Vision of the Visionary

WHEN I AM DOWN AND, OH,
MY SOUL, SO WEARY
WHEN TROUBLES COME AND
MY HEART BURDENED BE
THEN I AM STILL AND WAIT
HERE IN THE SILENCE
UNTIL YOU COME AND SIT
AWHILE WITH ME
YOU RAISE ME UP SO I CAN
STAND ON MOUNTAINS
YOU RAISE ME UP TO WALK
ON STORMY SEAS
I AM STRONG WHEN I AM ON
YOUR SHOULDERS
YOU RAISE ME UP TO MORE
THAN I CAN BE
YOU RAISE ME UP SO I CAN
STAND ON MOUNTAINS
YOU RAISE ME UP TO WALK
ON STORMY SEAS
I AM STRONG WHEN I AM ON
YOUR SHOULDERS
YOU RAISE ME UP TO MORE
THAN I CAN BE



YOU RAISE ME UP (UP) SO
I CAN STAND ON
MOUNTAINS (STAND ON
MOUNTAINS)
YOU RAISE ME UP TO
WALK ON STORMY SEAS
(STORMY SEAS)
I AM STRONG (I AM
STRONG) WHEN I AM ON
YOUR SHOULDERS (OOH)
YOU RAISE ME UP TO
MORE THAN I CAN BE
YOU RAISE ME UP (UP) SO
I CAN STAND ON
MOUNTAINS (STAND ON
MOUNTAINS)
YOU RAISE ME UP TO
WALK ON STORMY SEAS
(STORMY SEAS)
I AM STRONG WHEN I AM
ON YOUR SHOULDERS
YOU RAISE ME UP TO
MORE THAN I CAN BE

